Someone Comes to Mind · Book Two

# The One Who Never Asked

Going where nothing comes back

— Before You Start 3

— Opening 6

1 Attach a Condition and It Becomes a Trade 8

2 The Eye Goes to the One Doing Worse 14

3 Once You Start Weighing Who Deserves It 19

4 To Someone You Will Never See Again 24

5 The Ones Who Withhold a Name 29

6 Deciding Not to Collect 34

7 At a Loss, and Still 40

8 Cutting a Piece Off Your Own 46

9 To Someone Who Is Not Grateful 51

10 Feeding People 56

11 Ask the Price and It Breaks 62

12 And Still They Give 68

# Before You Start

## ◆ This Is the Second

You can read this without having read the first. The first looked at the receiving side and this one looks at what the received thing does as it moves on, so reading them in order joins a line. The line is drawn on the covers.

| Book | What it looks at |
|---|---|
| One · The One Who Was Already There | What had arrived before I ever asked |
| **Two · The One Who Never Asked** | Going toward what will not come back |
| Three · The One Who Stayed | What continues even when they do not know |

## ◆ Every Chapter Ends With a Box

## Someone Comes to Mind

Not something to do. Someone to remember. This book does not tell you to do anything. It points at what has already happened, and that happened to you, not to me. So that box is one I cannot fill.

### ◆ Every Chapter Leaves One Thing Open

A book about giving especially wants to close neatly. To keep myself from that, every chapter has one place where I do not have the answer. Warm writing collapses in exactly one spot: when it pretends the painful part does not hurt.

There are two painful chapters in this one. The second and the ninth. **A book that does not hurt is not a warm book.**

## ◆ And This Book Does Not Finish Either

No knot is tied in the last chapter. None is tied in the third book either.

## ◆ How the Facts Are Handled

Each chapter ends with Where This Chapter Came From, holding both what I checked and what I cut because I could not check it. Anything unverified was cut whole rather than softened.

# Opening

## ◆ Opening

One thing has to be cleared away before a book about giving. **How to give well is not in here.**

Those books exist and some are good. They tend to start in the same place. How do I give so it works. How do I give so the other person changes. How do I give so that I feel right. All of them are about giving with a result.

What this book looks at is the opposite side. **Going in the direction where there is no result.** Going where nothing comes back, going without weighing whether anyone deserves it, going to someone who will not be grateful. By the arithmetic all of it is a loss, and people are doing it.

Watch that and it does not explain. The side that explains well has already been covered by other books, so this one will stay on the side that does not. Twelve chapters, and one question follows all twelve.

> Why go where nothing comes back.

The first book held the front half of that question. What was received cannot be repaid, so it goes sideways, I wrote. If that is right then giving is passing something through, and passing something through needs no reason. Only, the explanation does not seem to cover all of it, which is why this book looks again.

# 1 · Attach a Condition and It Becomes a Trade

## ◆ Children Know First

The fastest people at telling conditional love from the other kind are children. They cannot explain it. They know all of it.

*Do well and I will buy it for you* and *I bought it because I thought you would like it* are places where the same object changes hands, and what the child receives is nothing alike, and the child who got the first treats the object as something they earned. The child who got the second knows they were thought of. **The object is the same and what was received is different.**

## ◆ Conditions Raise Performance

Something has to be written fairly here. Conditions work.

Attach one and people move. Marks rise, work gets done, promises are kept. Which is why nearly every institution in the world is built out of conditions, and without them neither a school nor a company runs, and to call conditions bad is to call the world bad, and a sentence like that does not land anywhere.

Conditions do have one property. The moment one is attached, that relationship becomes a trade, and a trade is not a bad thing and most of the world is trade, and **in a relationship built as a trade, when the condition ends the relationship ends.**

### ◆ You Find Out at the End

So which kind it was can only be known at the end.

When the marks stop coming. When the work falls through. When illness makes everything impossible. If

the person is still there then it was not a condition, and if they vanish then it was. It is a cruel test and not one anybody sets deliberately. Live long enough and it administers itself.

The first book looked only at the receiving side; here we look at the giving one. I wondered whether there is a way for the giver to tell whether they are attaching a condition, and there is one. **Picture what you would do if the other person became unable.** Even imagining it comes out fairly clear.

## ◆ Conditions Hide Inside Sentences

Conditions mostly hide inside sentences. And the hidden ones are stronger.

*I am proud of you* is a good sentence, and if it only comes out when there is something to be proud of, the sentence becomes a condition. So does *what a good girl.* Arriving only on the good days, it means that on the other days she is not a daughter. The

speaker has no intention of setting a condition and on the listening side it stacks up as one.

So to avoid conditions **you have to speak on the days when nothing happened.** Speak only on the days something went well and all of it turns conditional. Try it and it is difficult, because on the days when nothing happened there is nothing to say.

### ◆ Can There Be No Condition at All

Here is where this chapter stops.

Whether a person can be met with no condition at all I do not know. Parents are people too, so a child doing well makes them happier, and the happiness shows on their face. Showing on the face means the child reads it. Read, it becomes a condition. You cannot tell someone to hide their happiness either. Hidden, it is a different sort of lie.

So a state with no condition in it looks impossible for a human being, and what does look possible is **having both kinds of day: days with a condition on them and days without.** That is as far as I got.

### ◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Someone gave you something with no condition attached. Were you doing well at the time, or not. If what comes to mind is something you received while you were not doing well, that is what this chapter is pointing at.

### ◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside.

What conditional rewards do to a person's motivation has been studied a great deal, as far as I know. I did not use it. That direction turns this into a piece about teaching methods, and then we are back

at how to give so that it works. The opening said this book would not ask that question.

# 2 · The Eye Goes to the One Doing Worse

## ◆ Where the Eye Goes

Watch where a parent's eye goes in a house with several children and something odd is happening. It does not go to the one doing well. It goes to **the one it is not working out for.**

They think longer about the child with poor marks than the one with good ones, and their body moves first toward the sick child rather than the healthy one. Of the child doing fine out in the world it is enough to hear news. The one not doing fine keeps them awake. By the arithmetic this is backwards. Investment goes more heavily into what is working, and people do the opposite.

## ◆ The One Receiving That Look Does Not Know

Stranger still, the one receiving the look does not know it.

The child on the side where it is not working out often feels less loved. The look is coming toward them more and they feel that anyway. It is because the look arrives in the shape of worry. Worry is received as nagging, and once it is received as nagging it does not read as love.

And the child on the side where it is working out feels slighted too. They feel nobody comes their way. Both feel slighted and the look is on one side. **Nobody is at fault and all three of them are hurt.**

## ◆ The Arithmetic Stands Backwards

There is one thing to set down in this chapter. **The arithmetic of love stands backwards to the arithmetic of investment.**

Investment puts more into what will return. Love puts more into what will not. Investment pulls out when the loss grows and love puts in more. Which is why every attempt to explain love as investment jams at some point, and the point is always about the same, and it jams in front of the child for whom nothing is working.

## ◆ To the Other Children

One thing has to be stated plainly. Telling the others that the look going one way does not mean they are loved less is **true, and no comfort at all on the listening side.**

The one on the side that is doing fine carries that slight for life. And the slight is hard to say out loud, because saying it makes you the selfish one, and that is what the well sibling goes through in a house with a sick one, and the story rarely gets told. I have not yet made anything I could say to them.

## ◆ So Should It Be Split Evenly

Here is where this chapter is stuck.

Splitting it evenly looks fair, and split evenly, the side that needs more comes up short. Give by need and it does not look fair. Give fairly and somebody goes without. Both are right and both are wrong.

And the parent is not choosing this anyway. The eye goes by itself. What it means to argue right and wrong about something nobody chooses I do not know, so the chapter stops here.

## ◆ Someone Comes to Mind

In your house the look went more to one side. Were you that side, or the other. Either way, if what you felt then is still there, the feeling is not wrong.

## ◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside.

What the other children go through in a house with a sick sibling has been studied. I did not use it. Bring that material here and those people become case studies, and this chapter is not looking at cases but inside that house, and that the material exists is worth recording, so that anyone who wants more can find it.

# 3 · Once You Start Weighing Who Deserves It

## ◆ A Line Forms

The first thing that appears once you start weighing who deserves something is a line.

Deserving requires comparison, and to work out who has the better claim you have to set two or more of them side by side, and set side by side, a front and a back appear. So the instant deserving is weighed, an order is manufactured among people. That order was not there before. The side that started weighing put it in.

## ◆ A Back of the Line Appears

Where there is a line there is necessarily a back of it. That is the nature of deserving.

Rank who deserves help and somebody comes out least deserving, and that person is very often the one who needs it most, because having the weakest claim usually means having the least, or having nothing to show. **That is how the person who needs it most ends up standing at the back.**

This is not the work of bad people. It is what came of trying to be fair. Fairness presumes a line, and as long as there is a line there is a back of it.

## ◆ Going Toward the Undeserving

So there is a separate kind of giving that does not weigh deserving.

No line formed, nobody asked who has the better claim, it simply goes to whoever is in front of you. Nobody asks about deserving where food is being

handed out. There is almost no place where someone serving a meal weighs whether this person has earned it.

Why food is exempt is curious. With money it gets weighed and with food it gets weighed less. Probably because food is more urgent, and if people set down the arithmetic in front of what is urgent, that is close to what this book is looking at.

### ◆ Not Weighing It Costs You

Something has to be written fairly. Not weighing deserving costs you.

It goes to people who have not earned it, it goes to people who are lying, and some people receive twice and three times. Deserving was invented to stop that, and remove it and that starts happening again. So *abolish deserving* is not a sentence this chapter can say.

What can be set down is that weighing also has a price. **The labor of weighing, the people who go without while it is weighed, and the person at the back.** That price does not usually make it into the calculation.

## ◆ How Far Should It Be Weighed

Here is where this chapter is stuck.

Weigh nothing and the system collapses. Weigh everything and the one who needs it most is pushed back. There is a line somewhere between, and the line differs by place and by season. And the person drawing it is usually standing near the front, so they draw it without knowing what the back of the line is like.

Knowing that, I still cannot draw it. Every time I drew one and looked, it had come out favoring the side I was standing on.

## ◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Someone never asked whether you deserved it. Did you deserve it at the time. You probably did not. You did not and you received it, and that is why it is still in your memory.

## ◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside.

There is certainly a great deal of research on what actually happens inside systems that assess eligibility. I did not look. That direction makes this a critique of policy, and this book cannot be that book, and the passage about food is written from what I have seen, and how common it is I do not know.

# 4 · To Someone You Will Never See Again

## ◆ Toward a Face You Do Not Know

Anyone who has given blood knows. You do not know where it goes.

There is no way to find out and nobody tells you. Who received it, whether they lived, whether they were grateful, all of it ends unknown. And people do it. Not once and done either; plenty of them keep at it for years. **There really are kinds of giving in this world that go in a direction where nothing at all comes back.**

## ◆ Not Even Gratitude

Giving of this kind does not even get gratitude back.

Gratitude is the small return the giver receives, and send it toward a face you do not know and there is none of that either, and by the arithmetic it is a total loss. Time goes in, the body takes some damage, and what returns is zero.

They do it anyway. And having done it they do not feel bad. This is the part that does not explain well. There are not many things in the world where you take a loss and feel all right about it.

### ◆ The Ones Who Withhold Their Name

Some go further. They give without giving their name.

Withhold the name and the channel for gratitude is sealed off entirely. The one who received cannot repay even if they want to. So hiding a name is also **work done to erase the receiver's debt.** The tenth chapter of the first book said the repayment counter is closed. Here the giving side closes it deliberately.

Why they close it would have to be asked, and it cannot be. They withheld their name. That is the strangest part of this chapter. There is structurally no way to learn their reasons.

### ◆ Easier Than the People Close to You

One thing should be written honestly. **Giving to a stranger is sometimes easier than giving to someone close.**

There are no expectations of a stranger. You never have to watch whether they are grateful, and you cannot see whether they use it well. So there is nothing to be hurt by. All the complicated things that come up when you give to someone close drop out here.

So if reading this chapter produces the thought *well, I am good at giving to strangers*, that may not be entirely good news, and the hard side is usually the near side.

## ◆ Is This Just Self-Satisfaction Then

Here is where this chapter is stuck.

If you feel all right afterward, the objection runs, is that feeling not the return, and then it is not a total loss, and if it is not a total loss the premise of the chapter wobbles. The objection is fairly strong.

There is one odd thing in it though. Go after that feeling and it does not come. Give in order to get the feeling and the feeling does not arrive. So it is a return, and a return that vanishes when it becomes the aim. What to call a return like that I do not know.

## ◆ Someone Comes to Mind

You have received something from a person whose face you have never seen.

Blood, maybe. An organ, maybe. Maybe just money. Or maybe a road or an alphabet that somebody laid

down a long time ago. That person does not know you were born.

## ◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside.

Blood donation and organ donation have numbers attached. How many people, how often, which countries do more. **I did not use them.** Put a figure in and this becomes a chapter about policy, and policy leads to how we get more people to do it. This chapter means to stop at not knowing why they do.

It would be worth looking at those numbers once before publication and deciding again whether leaving them out is right.

# 5 · The Ones Who Withhold a Name

## ◆ What the Last Chapter Could Not Ask

The last chapter said the reasons of people who withhold their name cannot be asked for. This chapter starts there. Since they cannot be asked, I will only guess.

## ◆ Guess One — To Keep the Receiver Light

The first is to keep the receiver light.

Know the name and you have to repay. Unable to repay, you feel bad. Feeling bad, you start avoiding them. So hiding the name is easier on the one receiving. What was given is received intact and no debt appears.

If that is right, hiding a name is **giving a second time.** You give the thing, and then you clear away the debt attached to the thing. Two gifts in one motion.

### ◆ Guess Two — A Name Changes the Shape

The second concerns the giver.

Attach a name and the act becomes that person's act, it becomes *so-and-so did such-and-such*, and then people begin to appraise it. Did a lot. Did little. Just like them. The instant appraisal attaches, the act is a different act.

Withhold the name and all of that falls away. The act remains and the person does not. Some people want that. Why they want it I again do not know, and there really are people who find it hard to bear having their name attached.

### ◆ Guess Three — Because It Is Not Theirs

The third is the one I find most plausible.

Sometimes the giver does not regard the act as their own, and if you think you are only passing on what you received, there is no reason to sign it, and it is like a courier not writing their own name on a parcel.

The eleventh chapter of the first book said what we receive goes sideways, and if that is right, the giver is someone standing in the middle, and people standing in the middle do not sign. Whether this guess is right I do not know. Looked at this way, the first two guesses get explained along with it.

### ◆ Some Do Give Their Names

It would be unfair to write up only one side. People give with their names attached, and there is nothing wrong with it.

Attach a name and the next person follows. Watching and learning starts happening, and it

sometimes spreads a long way. If nobody ever gave a name, nobody would know such a thing existed in the world. So there is a use to naming, and the hiding side does not have that use.

## ◆ Which Is Better

Here is the stuck place.

Hide it and the receiver is light; name it and the next person follows, and both are good and they cannot be done together and choosing one means discarding the other.

Different people choose differently, and what they are choosing on they cannot explain well themselves. I cannot choose either. Only, looking at the ones who hide it does something strange to me, and that strange feeling is what made me write the chapter.

## ◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Among the things you have received there is one whose giver you will never know. That person took away your chance to be grateful. Whether that is unkind or kind I still do not know.

## ◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside. All of it is guesswork and it is marked as guesswork.

Whether anyone has actually surveyed people who give without their names I did not look up. Even if such a survey exists I doubt they answered. Answering gives you a name.

# 6 · Deciding Not to Collect

## ◆ The Arithmetic Is Odd

Set the word forgiveness down for a moment and look only at what happens inside it. What happens is this. **The side with something owed to them decides not to collect.**

By the arithmetic this is odd. There is a right to collect, the right is legitimate, and not collecting is a loss of exactly that size. And they do not collect. And having decided not to, the person gets lighter. Taking a loss and getting lighter has come up again.

## ◆ It Is Not the Same as Forgetting

One thing has to be separated out first. Deciding not to collect is not the same as forgetting.

Forgetting is the arithmetic disappearing, and the memory dims until the fact that anything was owed no longer comes to mind, and that is the work of time rather than the work of a person.

Deciding not to collect is done **with the arithmetic perfectly clear.** You know the amount, you know you could collect, and you do not. The sharper the memory the harder it is, which is why this is not something that happens by itself as time passes.

### ◆ The Other Person Does Not Need to Know

There is one curious feature. It holds even if the other person never knows.

There is no need to inform them that you decided not to collect. Informing them makes it stranger, in fact. *I have forgiven you* is not a good sentence to be on the receiving end of, and there is a position of looking down built into it, so the listener ends up in debt all over again.

So this is mostly done alone. Done alone and told to nobody. The third book looks at things that continue even when the other person does not know, and this belongs over there too.

### ◆ There Are Days It Does Not Work

Let me write this honestly. It does not happen in one go.

You think you have done it, and months later the thing surfaces again, and surfacing, it makes you angry again. Then it seems you did not do it. So you do it again. It surfaces again and you do it again, and it is not a thing that finishes once but **a thing done many times**, and needing many times does not look like evidence of failure.

There is a reason for writing this part down. Some people decide they are inadequate because it did not work in one go. The nature of the thing seems to be like that.

## ◆ Cases Where You Do Not Have To

And something must be written here. **There are cases where you do not have to.**

A piece that urges someone badly hurt not to collect becomes a form of violence. This chapter must not be held up in front of someone still in pain, someone for whom it is not over, someone whose other party is still doing the same thing.

This chapter is not telling anyone to do it. It is looking at the fact that such a thing exists in the world. Blur that distinction and this becomes a bad book.

## ◆ I Do Not Know Why It Gets Lighter

Here is the stuck place.

I do not know why deciding not to collect makes a person lighter. By the arithmetic the loss has just been locked in, so why does the weight drop. Perhaps

holding something owed is itself heavy, and then it would follow that the more you are owed the heavier you are, which is strange in its own way.

I tried several explanations and each jammed somewhere. I am leaving it jammed.

### ◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Someone is owed something by you and has not collected.

You may not even know that they did not. That is the nature of the thing. If anything does come to mind, today would be a good day to think about it once.

### ◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside.

This subject has a great deal of research behind it. There are several studies measuring what changes in body and mind, as far as I know. **I did not use them.** Write down the benefits and this becomes a chapter that says *so do it*, which runs head–on into the section about the cases where you do not have to.

# 7 · At a Loss, and Still

## ◆ Places Where the Arithmetic Does Not Work

Gather up what this book has looked at so far and one thing catches. None of the arithmetic works.

Attach no condition and the effect drops. Let your eye go to the one doing worse and there is no return. Do not weigh deserving and things leak. Give to a stranger and nothing comes back. Hide your name and even that is gone. Decline to collect and the loss is locked in. **Six chapters, all of them stories about losing.**

And people are doing it. Not one or two people. A very great many, and they have been at it for thousands of years.

## ◆ The Loss Is in the Design

Let me set one thing down here. The loss does not look like an accident. It looks like part of the design.

Design the giving well and you can make it lose nothing. Attach conditions, weigh deserving, put your name on it, collect what is owed. Do that and efficiency rises and the leaks shrink. Plenty of organizations really do work this way.

And once it is built that way it has become something else. The name changes. From then on it is called a business or a program, and nobody calls it love. **The moment the loss is removed the name changes** is the strangest thing in this chapter.

## ◆ Where Does the Strength to Bear It Come From

To keep going while losing, something has to be holding it up. I have thought about what that might be.

Willpower does not last long enough. Willpower bottoms out in months and some people do this for decades. Character does not work either, because the people who do it are so unlike one another. Reward does not work, because as the previous chapters showed, there is no reward.

One thing is left, which is the explanation from the first book. **Passing on what was received.** If you are not handing over something of your own but letting it through, then the word loss never applied. No pipe takes a loss from the water going through it.

That explanation has a hole in it too. The eleventh chapter looks at the hole.

### ◆ They Do Not Calculate the Loss

One observation to record. Watch people who give for a long time and **they do not calculate the loss.**

They do not know how much they have given. Ask and they say they are not sure. It is not that they have forgotten. It looks as though they never counted. So they have no sensation of loss, and with no sensation the point at which they tire is different.

People who count get tired. Count and one day *after all I have done* arrives without fail, and once that sentence is out, everything after it is a trade.

## ◆ So Am I Saying Do Not Count

Here is the stuck place.

Say do not count and it easily becomes a way of saying do not look after yourself. I have seen people who gave everything away and collapsed. Telling them not to count is a dangerous sentence.

Then how far should anyone count, and that line is different for every person and I cannot draw somebody else's. *The people who do not count last*

*longer* and *not counting makes people collapse* are both correct, and I am leaving them without putting them in one sentence.

### ◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Someone did something for you at a cost to themselves. They would not have thought of it as a cost. Ask them and they will say no. That answer is what this chapter is pointing at.

### ◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside. Observation and guesswork, with the guesswork marked as guesswork.

There is probably research on people who give over long periods. I did not look. Find it and this becomes a chapter called five traits of such people, and then it

is a list to follow, and this book started out having decided not to make lists.

# 8 · Cutting a Piece Off Your Own

## ◆ Ask What They Gave

Ask people what they gave up for somebody and they start with money. Listen a little longer and it is not about money.

A story about nights comes out. A story about years handed over, about studies abandoned, about places never gone to. Money gets the shortest telling and is forgotten the soonest, because money earned once can be earned again and those few years cannot.

So looking at the amount tells you almost nothing about an act of giving. **You have to look at the place it was cut from.**

## ◆ The Cut Does Not Fill In

Money spent can be replaced. Time spent cannot.

During the two years a child was ill, somebody went two years backward in their own work. Those two years are never made up later. The people who started alongside them moved forward in the meantime, and coming back, the ground has shifted. Call that a loss and it is a loss.

Here is the odd part. Ask those people what they would do if the two years could be returned to them, and mostly no answer comes, and they say it was costly and they do not say they would not do it. They live in both at once.

## ◆ Sleep

The thing cut away most often is sleep. And it is the thing least counted.

Anyone who has raised an infant had their nights in pieces for years, and the same goes for anyone who

nursed someone ill, and for anyone who looked after an aging parent. Nobody counts the hours lost. Counting changes nothing, and once you start counting, the night gets longer.

You can recognize the face of someone who has been cutting away sleep. They cannot see it and from the outside it shows. That face is the whole of what this chapter is trying to say.

## ◆ Room

Of everything that gets cut away, the least sensible is room.

In a small house, when the children increase, somebody's space shrinks. The side that shrinks is almost always the adult. The larger person moves into the smaller spot. By the arithmetic this is backwards and it happens in house after house.

The side that shrank does not even call it giving way. They simply sit like that. The giving with no name on it is the most common kind, and with no name on it, it is recorded nowhere.

## ◆ How Much Can Be Cut

Here is where this chapter jams.

Writing only well of cutting away is dangerous. There are people who cut away everything and had nothing left, and after they collapsed there was no one to give, and the side that had been receiving had a harder time. So giving everything is not the same as giving the most.

Then how far, and I cannot draw the line. Draw one and it becomes an excuse. Do not draw one and somebody goes all the way. I cannot answer for either, so I am leaving it undrawn. One sentence can be set down. **Telling someone who has nothing left to put out more is not a sentence that belongs to love.**

## ◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Someone went several years backward for you. You do not know what they might have done with those years. If you have never asked, it is not too late.

## ◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside. There is research measuring the hours that care work takes. I did not use it. Turn time into a number and the number converts into money, and converted, the chapter stands on its head.

There is research on the sleep deprivation of people providing care as well. Left out for the same reason. That both exist is worth recording.

# 9 · To Someone Who Is Not Grateful

## ◆ The Hardest Side

The fourth chapter said giving to a stranger is hard. There is a harder side. **Someone you know, who does not say thank you.**

A stranger never had the chance to be grateful. Someone you know had the chance and did not take it. On the receiving end that difference is very large.

## ◆ Three Different Things

There are several places where thanks does not come back, and they are not alike.

The first is not knowing. An infant is like that. So is someone whose memory is going. This side does not

hurt. Few people feel slighted by a person who could not have known.

The second is knowing and not doing it. They take it as a given. Children are mostly like this with parents, and old friends are like it with each other. This side stings a little. And it is bearable.

Then there is a third. The one who received turns around and resents you, and they say they never asked you to do it, that their life came out this way because of it. That one hurts most. And it is more common than people expect.

## ◆ What Thank You Does

I have wondered why that sentence gets waited for so badly.

It is not money. Hearing it leaves nothing in your hand. And hearing it makes what you did into a thing that happened. Not hearing it makes it as

though nothing occurred at all, and people want what they did to be written down somewhere, and thank you is the sound of the writing.

When the sound does not come, it goes by unrecorded. Doing something unrecorded for several decades is the place this chapter sits.

## ◆ Wanting It Breaks It

Something catches here. Wanting to be thanked is not a bad thing, and if you are wanting it, the giving breaks off one day.

The order of the breaking is much the same every time. First you feel slighted, then you start counting, and once you have counted, *after all I have done* arrives, and once that sentence is out of your mouth it is hard to get back, and the receiving side hears it too. Hearing it, they are in debt, and once a debt appears, everything between you is arithmetic.

So the conclusion is do not want it, which is again not a sentence you can say to a human being. Wanting is not a thing anyone chooses.

## ◆ So What Do You Do

Here is where this chapter is stuck. I cannot write an answer.

Watch people who have given for a long time and it is not that they stopped wanting it. **They want it less.** Not gone, reduced. Ask how it reduced and they say it just did. Some say it was the years. Some say it reduced after they came to see what they themselves had received.

The second answer catches. It connects to what the first book set down, and if it is right, there is only one road to not wanting to be thanked. Seeing first what you were given. Whether that is a road I do not know either. I am recording only that several people said it that way.

## ◆ Someone Comes to Mind

There is someone you have never thanked. You took it as a given. They may still be waiting.

## ◆ Where This Chapter Came From

This chapter is observation and things I was told. I did not record who said them, because they were talking about their families.

There is probably research on the person being cared for coming to resent the person caring. I did not look. Put it in and the chapter becomes how to handle such cases, and that is not what this chapter is for.

# 10 · Feeding People

## ◆ The First Thing Received

The first thing a person receives is food. It arrives within hours of being born. It is received in a state of knowing nothing, and the receiving is not known either.

And the first thing a person gives to anyone else is usually food too. Watch children and you can see it. Before they have words they hold out their own biscuit. Nobody taught them and they do it. It is also the only giving available at that age.

Of all the ways of giving, feeding is the oldest. It is probably as old as people.

## ◆ Why Is It So Strong

Feeding has something in it that other kinds of giving do not. It moves people in a way that does not make sense.

Hear that someone is ill and people carry food to them. Go to a house where someone has died and there too they feed you. When there is nothing to say, people feed. Someone who cannot find the words for comfort will still make soup.

I have thought about why and I do not know. One part is guessable. Eating is something the body does, and what the body does leaves no room for words to get in, and it is what you do when you cannot speak, which is why it cannot be faked.

## ◆ The Side That Lays the Table

A table has two places at it. The eating place and the laying place. And the one who laid the table is almost never remembered for it.

Many people remember the food they ate as children. Few remember who made it and at what hour they got up. On the receiving side the food was simply there. It is the same place the first book described. **Seen from the receiving end, the food has always already been put out.**

And the one who laid it usually eats later. Eats it cold, eats what is left. That order is the same in house after house and nobody decided it.

### ◆ Why Feeding Never Gets Counted

Feeding is two or three times a day, and that goes on for decades.

Once is small. One meal is one meal, and nobody is grateful for a single meal having been cooked. And stacked up, it grows a person, and a small thing repeated tens of thousands of times becomes a large thing, and while it is stacking, each one is too small to be counted.

This looks like the reason most giving is invisible. Giving something big once is visible. Giving something small tens of thousands of times is not. And the second is the side that keeps people alive.

## ◆ Houses Where Nobody Fed Anyone

One side has to be set down here. Writing only well of the family table injures the people who grew up without one.

There are houses where nobody laid a table. There are people who grew up boiling their own noodles, and there were houses where the table was frightening. The table is not always warm. Someone who grew up in such a house reads this chapter and confirms once more what they did not have.

I have not yet made anything I could say to them. One thing shows, though. Among people who grew up in houses like that, some feed others extremely

well. They never received it and they are giving it. How that works is the eleventh chapter.

### ◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Someone made the food you ate longest. You may not know what hour they got up. Find out if you can, and if you cannot, it is enough to call the food to mind.

### ◆ Where This Chapter Came From

The passage about children is observation. There is research on children sharing food before they have language, and I confirmed from public sources that such work exists and did not use it in the text, because I could not read it properly. Summarizing what you have not read produces errors.

How widely the custom of bringing food to a house in mourning extends is something I tried to check

and could not. I wanted to write that it exists in every culture, and I could not find the material to support that, so the sentence came out.

# 11 · Ask the Price and It Breaks

## ◆ Up Front

Here is what this chapter has to set down. **The moment a price is asked, the thing becomes a different thing.** It does not break so much as change, and on the receiving side it feels like breaking.

And this chapter records that the explanation from the earlier chapters is short in one place. It is the place the seventh and tenth chapters put off.

## ◆ What Happens When a Price Attaches

Somebody does something for you and you ask what you owe, and the nature of the place changes. The size of the sum is irrelevant. It changes on the single fact that a price appeared.

A neighbor watched the children. Say thank you and the thing between you stays open. Ask what you should pay them and the thing between you is settled. Settled, it is finished. The side that paid is relieved of a debt and made comfortable, and in exchange for the comfort there is nothing more to come.

Why losing a debt should be a loss is the odd part. What is between people stays open only while something is still owed. Repay it all and the relationship is complete. A completed relationship has no next.

### ◆ Which Is Why They Will Not Take It

This looks like the reason givers refuse payment. They know that taking it closes the thing between you. Not knowing it in words. Simply knowing.

In the country there are people who wave a hand when you try to pay for something they gave you, and I used to think this was modesty and I see it

differently now. They are refusing to let the thing close. Money moving makes a neighbor into a supplier.

And the ones who refuse usually set you some other task instead. Come help in my field next time. That costs more. Choosing the more expensive one is what catches in this chapter.

## ◆ One Explanation Short

Now to the place that was put off.

The first book explained giving as passing something through. What was received cannot be repaid, so it goes sideways, I wrote. The seventh chapter used that to explain the strength to bear a loss. No pipe takes a loss from the water going through it, it said.

That explanation has a hole, and someone who received almost nothing should have almost nothing to pass on, and among people who received almost

**nothing there are some who give the most.** People who grew up without a table and who feed others extremely well. The place noted at the end of the tenth chapter.

What they have did not flow in from anywhere. So passing it through does not explain it.

## ◆ I Tried to Build Another and Stopped

So I tried to build a different explanation. Two of them.

One is that a person who has gone without knows that absence. Someone who was hungry recognizes someone hungry and feeds them. This is plausible and it does not fit everywhere. Not everyone who went without turns out this way. Going without makes people grip harder at least as often.

The other is that I failed to find what they received. Table or no table, somebody somewhere may have

looked at them once, and that once may have been a seed, and this one cannot be argued against, which is not a good sign. An explanation that cannot be argued against is usually not an explanation.

**Neither works.** I stop here. This book is looking at what happens on the giving side, and where that strength came from is not a question this book has standing to answer. That one explanation is missing is recorded plainly. Pretending otherwise would be worse.

### ◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Someone would not take payment from you. What were they protecting, that time.

### ◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside. Inference and observation, with the inference marked

as inference.

That a gift and a trade are different in kind has a long discussion behind it in anthropology. I confirmed from public sources that the discussion exists and did not bring it into the text. Summarize it here and the chapter becomes a tour of the literature, and then the neighbor who watched the children becomes a case study. Anyone interested will find it under gift exchange.

# 12 · And Still They Give

## ◆ Eleven Chapters of Why It Does Not Work

Read this far and one thing catches the eye. All eleven chapters have been about **why it does not work.**

Attach no condition and the effect drops. Look at the one doing worse and there is no return. Do not weigh deserving and it leaks. Give to a stranger and nothing comes back. Hide your name and even that is gone. Decline to collect and the loss is locked in. The time cut away never fills in. The thank you does not come. Feeding is never counted. Take payment and it closes. And why anyone does it, the eleventh chapter came up one explanation short.

Set out like that, there are eleven reasons not to.

## ◆ And They Do It

And people are doing it.

At this hour somebody is going without sleep, somebody is sending something without a name on it, somebody is laying out breakfast having never been thanked. Millions of them, for thousands of years. A thing with eleven reasons against it, done by that many people for that long.

That is the strangest fact in this book. And the most certain one. The explanation comes up short and **the only thing confirmed is that it is happening.**

## ◆ The Word *Still*

Ask people why they do it and the answers are short. They do not explain. They start to explain, stop, and say *still.*

Still, somebody has to. Still, what can you do. Still, he is my son. Still, they are a person. I have heard

this many times, and each time I have thought about what was left out in front of it. All eleven chapters of this book are inside that *still.* They know nothing is coming back, they know it is a loss, they know the thank you will not arrive. They know all of it and then still.

**They are not doing it in ignorance.** That is the weight of the word.

### ◆ What Is Left After the Arithmetic

By the arithmetic every chapter in this book is in deficit. And people carry that deficit for decades.

So it is one of two things. Either those people cannot do arithmetic, or the arithmetic we use does not fit this. I think it is the second. The people who have given longest were not bad at arithmetic. Most of them were extremely practical, and quick with figures in every other part of life. They simply did not use arithmetic here.

When something continues without the arithmetic working, something other than arithmetic is holding it up. What that is I did not find in this book.

## ◆ And It Does Not Stop

One thing is left at the end.

This book looked only at what happens on the giving side. And the people it looked at have one more thing in common. **They do not quit.** Something seems to continue when nothing comes back, when the other person cannot recognize them, after that person is gone. None of that was looked at here. Look at it here and this book gets long and slack.

So this book stops. That the arithmetic does not work and people are doing it anyway is as far as it went. Why they do not quit has not been written down yet.

## ◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Someone did a *still* for you.

They will have known all of it. They will have known nothing was coming back, and that they might never hear a thank you. They did it knowing. They have not explained it, and they may never.

## ◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside. It stands on what the preceding eleven chapters brought.

The near-absence of outside material here is for the same reason as the first book. There were several places where material existed and it was left out. Putting it in makes the person in that place a case study, and the decision was taken each time and the trace of it is at the end of each chapter.

The One Who Never Asked · Someone Comes to Mind · Book Two